

VU Boss

Dinky Desktop Power

The VU Boss is a small form factor PC that targets the growing trend of small and slim in the lifestyle segment of Desktop computing.

This PC is tiffin-box-sized. The wireless RF keyboard incorporates a tracker ball and is the sole input device. The ball is placed on the right, with the click buttons on the left—these allow for free use of the keyboard in your palms.

The 22-inch widescreen LCD panel makes the VU Boss a pleasure of a computing experience. On a sour note, accessing the power switch on the box becomes a tricky thing when it's behind the LCD. In a cold start scenario, the power switch on the keyboard just doesn't work, making one depend on the

main power switch on VU—difficult to get to if the box is hooked behind the 22-inch panel.

The LCD panel's base is sturdy, but there's no swirl—not a good thing for a big screen. The integrated 2 W stereo speakers in the LCD panel just manages to get the job done! The S-Video/DVI out ports being on the back panel of the VU PC beside the AV/TV in ports makes hooking up to a TV straightforward job: this is a viable idea for a media centre PC.



Taking the box apart reveals the Intel Mobile class Core Duo T2350 (1866 MHz) processor running on the Intel i945GM chipset. The integrated INTEL GMA 950 graphics solution manages a score of 396 in 3D Mark 05—decent for a machine of this form factor.

The PC Mark 05 score of 2985 reflects average processing power. The VU PC is pre-loaded with Windows XP Professional,

and with 512 MB of RAM, performance is good enough for word processing, surfing, and other everyday computing staples. The optical drive is a smooth-operating slide-in Matshita DVD-ROM.

Rs 65,000 for the VU Boss doesn't make too much sense in terms of value. But if you have a really cramped desk and are looking for a space-saving Desktop—besides a 22-inch widescreen—the VU Boss might prove worth it.

Specifications

Intel Core Duo T2350 mobile processor; Intel i945GM chipset; 512 MB DDR2 RAM; Matshita DVD-ROM; 80 GB HDD; 22-inch widescreen LCD panel

Contact: Vu Technologies Pvt Ltd
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Web site: www.technologies.vu
Price: Rs 65,000

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

Thecus N4100

Stack your data!

The Intel XScale-based N4100 NAS (Network Attached Storage) server by Thecus is an excellent answer to your data sharing, storage, and backup needs. Less than half the size of a regular PC cabinet, the N4100 is sturdily built. It has four drive caddies that can hold a 500 GB SATA hard drive each, thus touching 2 TB.

Installing drives is a cinch; thanks to the precision rail mechanism, the drive gets neatly engaged with the SATA connectors inside—no cables involved. The activity LEDs indicate drive status. Bearing no resemblance to boring file servers, it is, in fact, very presentable, and you wouldn't mind letting it adorn your desktop!

The CD guides you through the process of initialising the server, and also lets you configure the

hard drives in RAID 0, 1, JBOD, or even RAID 5 arrays if you give data security top priority. The easy-to-use browser interface also allows you to set up the N4100 as an FTP, iTunes, file, print, or a backup server, and lets you create shared folders, with user and group access rights.

If a drive fails, Hot PnP lets you remove it on the fly and replace it with a new one, and the server won't be down at all. The RAID array starts getting rebuilt as soon as the hard drive is replaced, or even when a new drive is added. Alarms sound when one of the drives fails, and an e-

mail alert is sent to the system admin.

It takes just over two minutes to transfer a 1 GB file to the N4100—good enough. The only problem here is inadequate ventilation, even with the 80 mm fan at the back.

In addition to the setup program, the accompanying CD contains a backup utility.

Unfortunately, the N4100 will set you back by a good Rs 37,500, which will put it out of reach of most SoHos. And yes, we must remind you that the N4100 does not come with any hard drives.



memory: 16 MB; interfaces:

2 x Gigabit ports, 2 x USB 2.0 ports; RAID levels: 0, 1, 5, JBOD; 4 x SATA drive bays; maximum capacity: 2 TB (4 x 500 GB); dimensions: 167 x 199 x 223 mm (W x H x D); power supply: 200 W; client platforms: Windows 98/ME/NT/2000/XP, UNIX/Linux/BSD (by CIFS), Apple OS X (AFP)

Contact: Apical Impex Pvt Ltd
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Web site: www.apical.in
Price: Rs 37,500

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★
Features	★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★
Overall	★★★★

Specifications

CPU: Intel IOP; SATA controller: Intel (supports Hot PnP); memory: 128 MB DDR; Flash